

JONAS

THE PROPHECY OF JONAS.

PREFACE.

Jonas prophesied in the reign of Jeroboam II. as we learn from 4 K. xiv. 25. to whom also he foretold his success in restoring all the borders of Israel. He was of Geth --- Opher, in the tribe of Zabulon, and consequently of Galilee; which confutes that assertion of the Pharisees, (John vii, 52.) that no prophet ever arose out of Galilee. He prophesied and prefigured in his own person the death and resurrection of Christ, and was the only one among the prophets who was sent to preach to the Gentiles. Ch. --- The most incredible mystery in our religion, and the vocation of the Gentiles, are thus insinuated. C. --- The latter shall be saved if they repent, like Ninive. W.

--- Paine's supposition, that this book was written by a pagan "to satirise the malignant character of a predicting priest," requires no refutation. H. Watson.

JONAS 1

CHAPTER I.

Ver. 2. Ninive, the capital city of the Assyrian empire. Ch. --- It was 150 stadia long and 90

broad, (Diod. ii.) on the western bank of the Tigris. Pliny vi. 13. --- Mosul, which some mistake for it, stands on the northern side. See Gen. x. 10. At the time when Jonas preached, Ninive would contain about 600,000. C. iv. 11. They were people less favoured by God, (Acts xiv. 15.

C.) but not abandoned. Theod. --- God took sufficient care of all his creatures, and foretold many things relating to foreign nations. C. --- Rom. iii. 29. W. ---

For the. Sept. add, "cry of." Gen.

iv. and xviii. H.

Ver. 3. Tharsis. Which some take to be Tharsus of Cilicia, others to be Tartessus of Spain, others to be Carthage. Ch. --- Joppe, now Jaffa, (M.) a miserable seaport. H. --- It was formerly the best near Jerusalem, (2 Par. ii. 16.) though very dangerous. Jos. Bel. iii. 15. or 29. --- It is said to have been built before "the inundation" of the world, (Mela. i. 11.) and was famous for the adventure of Andromeda, rescued by Perseus from a sea monster. Pliny v. 13.

C. --- Lord. He feared being accounted a false prophet, (W.) knowing how much God was inclined to shew mercy, (C. iv. 2.) and being disheartened at the difficulty of the undertaking, like Moses and Gedeon. C. --- He might also think that if the Ninivites repented, it would be a reflection on the obstinacy of the Jews. S. Greg. Mor. vi. 13. S. Jer.

Ver. 4. Broken. Seeing no natural cause of such a sudden tempest, they concluded (W.) that some on board must be guilty; as the sailors argued (H.) when the noted atheist, Diagoras, was in similar circumstances. C. --- They had recourse to lots, and the prophet consented by God's inspiration, (W.) though this is not written, (H.) and the lots were superstitious. M. --- The oriental writers add many things to this sufficiently marvellous account. Lyran.

D'Herbelot. C.

Ver. 5. God. They were idolaters. v. 6. --- Wares, which is commonly done in storms. C. ---

This loss was in punishment of their sins; though they seem not devoid of some fear of God and man. H. --- Sleep. This is a lively image of the insensibility of sinners, fleeing from God, and threatened on every side with his judgments; and yet sleeping as if they were secure. Ch. --- Yet Jonas was sleeping through grief. S. Jer. Mat. xxvi. 40. C.

Ver. 9. Fear, and therefore fly from the face of the Lord. v. 3, 10. H. --- He knew that God is every where, v. 3. Ps. cxxxiii. 8. C. --- Sept. "I

worship." Fear is often taken in this sense. H.

Ver. 12. Cast me. God intimates that he required this sacrifice. M.

Ver. 13. Hard. They were unwilling to destroy the prophet, (C.) fearing to incur fresh guilt by thus treating one who had intrusted his life to them. Jos. Ant. ix.

11.

Ver. 14. Blood. We act thus by his direction, and through necessity.

Ver. 16. Lord. They were converted by this prodigy, and offered sacrifice immediately, or (C.) when they came to port. M. --- All know by the light of reason that sacrifice and vows are acceptable to the Lord. W.

JONAS 2

CHAPTER II.

Ver. 1. Fish. Heb. dag: afterwards daga occurs, v. 2; (H.) on which Leusden observes, the Jews infer that Jonas was first swallowed up by male and then by a female fish, which being full of young he was much straitened, and prayed from the belly of that (hadaga) female fish! He alludes to R. Jarchi. H.

--- Thus nar, puer, is put for a girl, to imply that Rebecca was prudent and Dina rambling. Buxt. Tib. 13. See Kennicott, Dis. 2. p. 417 and 552.
--- Noble discoveries!

Many suppose (H.) that this fish was a whale, as it does not live on flesh; (C.) but its throat being so narrow, as hardly to suffer a man's arm to pass, it is more probable that it was the sea-dog, lamia or canis chariarias, (Bartolin 14.) which may easily contain a man. Aldrovandus iii. 32.

M. --- This sea-dog, or shark, has five rows of teeth in each jaw. Human bodies have been found entire in the stomach. Button. --- Our Saviour

calls the fish a whale, Mat. xii. 40. W. --- But that term is given to any great sea monster. Yet it is not of much importance what species of fish be meant, provided the miracle be admitted. C. --- The pagans ridiculed it. S. Aug. ep. 102. q. 6. 30.

--- Yet they believed many of a similar nature, alleging the omnipotence of God.

S. Jer. --- This reason accounts for all the miracles recorded in Scripture. But might not God have chosen some easier expedient? We must not dive into his reasons. The impression which such a fact would make on the Ninivites, and the prefiguring of Christ's burial, might suffice. Jonas was not a type of his death, as some have imagined, Q. ad Orthodox. C. --- Nights, or as long as our Saviour was in the monument, (M.) which was about thirty-four hours. C. Dis.

Ver. 2. Prayed. He entertained these sentiments. Sanct. xiv. --- He afterwards wrote them down.

C.

Ver. 3. I cried. These five verses (H.) express his thoughts while he was in the sea, (S. Jer. C.) or in the fish. H. --- He doubtless prayed before, when he was cast into the sea, and also in the whale's belly, having then greater confidence that he should arrive safely on dry land, (v. 5.) and therefore vowing sacrifices of thanks, v. 10. W. --- Hell; the whale's belly, (Theod. &c.) or rather the depth of the sea. It may denote any imminent danger.

Ver. 5. Eyes, in a sort of despair, like the psalmist, xxx. 23. Yet he presently resumes fresh confidence in God, notwithstanding the greatness of his offences. --- Temple. He went to Jerusalem, like other good Israelites.

Ver. 6. Soul, so that I was in danger of being suffocated. Ps. lxviii. 2. C. - -- Sea.

Heb. "weeds entangled," &c. H. --- The Mediterranean has a great deal of sea weed. He speaks of the time before he was swallowed up by the fish.

Ver. 7. Lowest. Heb. and Sept. "clefts." --- Bars, or prisons, in the abyss, (C.) farthest from the heights. W.

Ver. 8. Me, at the last gasp, (C.) and oppressed with grief. M.

Ver. 9. Mercy. He alludes to the sailors. Theodoret --- Heb. also, "let them forsake their worship," (Drus. Lev. xx. 17.) or they are guilty of impiety. They neglect their vows. v. 10. C. i.

16. C.

Ver. 11. Spoke to the fish. God's speaking to the fish was nothing else but his will, which all things obey. Ch. W. --- Land. Josephus says near the Euxine Sea.

But thus it must have travelled 800 leagues. Others fix upon different places, without any proof. C.

JONAS 3

CHAPTER III.

Ver. 2. Bid thee before, or when thou shalt be there. C. --- He seems to have retired to Jerusalem.

M.

Ver. 3. Journey. By the computation of some ancient historians, Ninive was about fifty miles round: so that to go through all the chief streets and public places, was three days' journey. Ch.

--- Diodorus (iii. 1.) says Ninive was 150 stadia or furlongs in length. It must have been therefore 480 round; and as each furlong contains 125 paces of 5 ft.

each, the compass would be "60 Italian miles, (about 50 Eng.)" which would employ a person three days to go through the principal streets. W. --- Ninive

"was much larger than Babylon." Strabo xvi. --- Heb. "a great city of God,"

&c. denoting its stupendous size.

Ver. 4. Journey. He records what he said the first day, though he seems to have preached many (Theod.) even during forty days, after which time (H.) he expected the city would fall, and therefore retired out of the walls. C. iv. ---

Forty. Sept. three. S. Justin, (dial.) "three, or forty-three." Theodoret thinks that the mistake was made by some ancient transcriber, and has since prevailed in all the copies of the Sept. All the rest have forty. S. Aug. (de civ. Dei. xviii. 44.) believes the Sept. placed three for a mysterious reason. Origen (hom. xvi.

Num.) suggests that the prophet determined the number, and hence God did not execute the threat. C. --- This and many other menaces are conditional. If men repent, God will change his sentence. S. Chrys. S.

Greg. Mor. xvi. 18. W.

Ver. 5. God. They were convinced that he had wrought such wonders in the person of Jonas, with a desire of their welfare, particularly as he allowed them some delay. Accordingly they did penance for about forty days, and their conversion was so sincere, that Christ proposes it to his disciples. Mat. xii. 41.

C. --- Thus "the city was overturned in its perverse manners." S. Aug. de civ.

Dei. xxi. 24. and Ps. l. --- They were at an end, and the city was renovated. H.

Ver. 6. King Sardanapalus, (Salien, A. 3216) or rather his father, Phul, whom Strabo calls Anacyndaraxes, (C.) and who died in the year 3237, (Usher) four years after he had invaded Palestine. 4 K. xv. 19.

Ver. 7. Princes. Their consent was requisite, to form an irrevocable edict. Dan.

vi. 8. --- Men.

Even infants, according to the Fathers. Joel ii. 16. S. Basil adds also, the young of cattle. This was done to excite rational beings to repentance. Theod.

--- We do not find that cattle were deprived of food on such occasions among the Jews. But Virgil specifies that this was the case at the death of Cæsar, (Ecl.

v.) as it was in droughts among some nations of America. Horn ii. 13.

C. --- When people are greatly moved by repentance, they exceed in austerity; but if this be not indiscreet, God accepts of their good intention. W.

Ver. 10. Mercy. Heb. "repented," as some copies of the Sept. read, while others have, "was comforted." H. --- God suspended the stroke. But as the people soon relapsed, Sardanapalus burnt himself to death, and the city was taken, (S. Jer.) thirty-seven years after Jeroboam. A.

3257. Usher. --- Yet this was only a prelude to its future ruin, foretold by Tobias, (xiv. 5. in Gr.) and effected by Nabopolassar and Astyages. C. A. 3378. Usher.

--- The vestiges did not appear in the days of Lucian, (Charon. C.) soon after Christ. H.

JONAS 4

CHAPTER IV.

Ver. 1. Troubled. His concern was lest he should pass for a false prophet; or rather lest God's word, by this occasion might come to be slighted and disbelieved. Ch. --- He conjectured that God would spare the penitent Ninivites, and feared lest prophecies should be deemed uncertain.

But this doubt is solved by observing that some are conditional, (C. iii. 4. Jer.

xviii. 8.) as it proved here. When the people relapsed, they were afterwards destroyed. Nah. i. &c. W. C. iii.

10. --- The conversion of Ninive was an earnest of that of the Gentiles. C. ---

This being so intimately connected with the reprobation of the Jews, (H.) the prophet was grieved at the misery of the latter, (S. Jer.) which our Saviour and S. Paul bewailed. Acts xi. 2. Rom. x. 19. Lu. xix.

&c. Yet Jonas seems to have considered himself rather too much.

Ver. 5. Went, or "had gone," waiting for the city's ruin. C.

Ver. 6. The Lord God prepared an ivy. Hederam. In the Heb. it is kikajon, which some render a gourd; others a palmerist, or palma Christi. Ch. --- This latter is now the common opinion. S.

Jerom explains it of a shrub growing very fast in the sandy places of Palestine.

He did not pretend (C.) that hedera, or ivy, as Aquila translates, (H.) was the precise import; but he found no Latin term more resembling, (C.) as he observes here and in his letter to S. Aug. who had informed him that a certain bishop of Africa having read his version publicly, the audience was surprised at the change; and the Jews, "either through ignorance or malice," decided in favour of the old Greek and Latin version of gourd, which Prot. retain. H. --- But this does not grow so soon no more than the ivy. The palma Christi, or ricinus, does. The

Egyptians call it kiki, and the Greeks selicy prion. See Pliny xv. 7. Its foliage is thick, and its trunk hollow. C. --- But how came S. Jerom to be unacquainted with this plant? or why did he substitute one false name for another?

Ver. 8. Hot. Heb. also, "eastern and sultry," (H.) or silent, (C.) which instead of refreshing, served only to increase the heat, (H.) and to raise dust. Sept. Syr.

&c. agree with the Vulg.

Ver. 9. Death. The spirit of prophecy changes not the temper. C. --- Jonas had reason to be grieved, and so had God to shew mercy. In this history and prediction, who would have thought that Jonas had been a figure of our Saviour's death and resurrection, if he himself had not declared it? Mat. xii. W.

--- The prophet comes out of the fish alive, as Christ does from the tomb. He was cast into the sea to save those on board; Christ dies for the redemption of mankind.

Jonas had been ordered to preach, but did not comply till after his escape; thus the gospel was designed to be preached to the Gentiles, yet Christ would not have it done till he had risen. Mat.

xv. 26. The prophet's grief intimates the jealousy of the Jews; as his shade destroyed, points out the law, which leaves them in the greatest distress. The very name fish, ichthus, is a monogram of "Jesus Christ, the Son of God, a Saviour, (C.) or crucified." H. S. Paulinus, ep. 33. --- Hence Jonas most strikingly foreshowed Christ. S. Aug. de civ. Dei. xviii. 30.